desert), estuary (between fresh water and saltwater) and riverbank or marshland (between dry and wet).

36. Sometimes the number of species and the population density of some of the species in the ecotone is much greater than either community. This is called edge effect. The organisms which occur primarily or most abundantly in this zone are known as edge species. In the terrestrial ecosystems edge effect is especially applicable to birds. For example, the density of birds is greater in the ecotone between the forest and the desert. Niche refers to the unique functional role and position of a species in its habitat or ecosystem. The functional characteristics of a species in its habitat is referred to as 'niche' in that common habitat.
37. Succession is characterised by the following: increased productivity, the shift of nutrients from the reservoirs, increased diversity of organisms, and a gradual increase in the complexity of food webs.
38. In primary succession on a terrestrial site, the new site is first colonised by a few hardy pioneer species that are often microbes, lichens and mosses. Lichen are plant-like organisms that consist of a symbiotic association of algae (usually green) or cyanobacteria and fungi. The pioneers over a few generations alter the habitat conditions by their growth and development
39.
    - Primary succession takes place over where no community has existed previously.
    - Such areas include rock outcrops, newly formed deltas and sand dunes, emerging volcano islands and lava flows, glacial moraines (muddy area exposed by a retreating glacier), etc. Unlike in the primary succession, the secondary succession starts on a well-developed soil already formed at the site. Thus, secondary succession is relatively faster.
40. In grasslands, grasses maintain status of climax due to following process:

    In the dry season the grasses dry up and cause fires which destroy other plant species and their seeds.

    - Also, grasslands develop in regions with scanty rainfall where plant growth cannot be achieved.